attended such festivals as representatives of the Sirkar, just as they also sat on temple management committees. One of Rous Peter's contemporaries next door in Travancore State was Colonel John Munro, whose place in Travancore's history has been recounted in Chapter 9. Munro is known to have presented 'a gaily decorated horse' and 'a big circular gold-plated umbrella with green glass stones suspended all around the frame' to the Padmanabhaswamy temple in Trivandrum,[3] as well as a pair of golden bangles to the Mahadeva temple at Chengannur, where Lord Shiva's *shakti* in the form of Bhagavathi is said to be subject to a monthly menstrual cycle. Here the local myth is that Munro laughed at this belief and stopped the funds that supported the monthly *Tripootharattu* rites performed by the temple's Nambudiri Brahmin priests. His wife then started to bleed incessantly and continued to do so until Munro was informed that this was a punishment for his insult to the goddess. Only when Munro had promised to set up a trust to fund the *Tripootharattu* did the bleeding stop, whereupon Munro presented the golden bangles in gratitude. All I can add to this is that John Munro had married Charlotte Blacker two years before he came to Travancore and that their first child was born in Scotland five years later.

This practice of British officials making presentations to temples continued for many years but went into decline following protests from Christian missionaries that this was pandering to idolatry. One of the earliest of these protestors was Charles Shubrick, Collector and Magistrate of Chingleput (Chengalpattu), who gained some notoriety in the 1850s for refusing on religious grounds to present a ceremonial shawl to the presiding deity at the Varadharaja Perumal Vishnu temple in Conjeeveram (Kanchipuram) – this despite the fact that a century earlier Robert Clive (the notorious 'Clive of India') himself had presented an emerald necklace to that same deity, today known as the Makarand